

Translation Studies

4. Linguistic models of the process of translation

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What it is exactly that takes place in the mind of the translator?

Analysis + synthesis



Modelling of the translating activity:

- = model of **text comprehension** (the way leading from the linguistic form to the mind)
- + **text production** (the way leading from the mind to the linguistic form)



How does the transfer from one sign system to the other take place?

- general consensus among the different branches of translation theory in the idea that there is no direct transfer;
- the process of translation consists of at least two phases:
 - (1) as the first step the translator analyses the SL text (the **analysis** phase),
 - (2) as the second step he/she constructs the TL text (the **synthesis** phase).



In between: the transfer phase

Nida's analogy of the process of translation:

■ “A useful analogy is that of crossing a broad, deep, swift river. If one does not know how to swim, and does not have a boat, it is necessary to go up and down the bank of the river until a place is found which is shallow enough to serve as a ford. The time and effort spent walking along one side of the river is not only not wasted; it is absolutely essential to the crossing.”
(Nida, 1969, p.34)



The most important problems related to the process of translation:

- How is the analysis conducted?
- In what language?
- In what phases?
- How is the synthesis conducted?
- In what language?
- In what phases?
- How do the analysis and synthesis relate to each other time-wise?
- How does the shift from one to the other take place?
- What is there between the two?



No general agreement among translation scholars.

- Some identify a **transfer phase** between the analysis and synthesis phase, + they argue for the existence of a special transitional, mediator language so called “**interlangauge**” operating in this phase.
- Others argue **against a rigid separation**, claiming that in the comprehension of the SL text the TL plays an important role, and vice versa, in the production of the TL text the SL has no small role, either (many translations exhibit traces of the FL).



The modelling of the process of translation

Revzin and Rozentsveig (1964) → two basic types of translation models:

- the **denotative** model (the way from the SL to the TL leads **through reality**, i.e., the translator uses his/her knowledge and previous experience of the world at the point of transfer) → “interpretation”
- the **transformational** model (there is a **direct** path from the SL to the TL) → “translation”



Another well known taxonomy: Komissarov's (1972, 1973) system

Contains the following models:

- (1) Denotative model
- (2) Transformational model
- (3) Semantic model
- (4) The model of equivalence-levels



Erdei (1979) offers the following classification:

(1) **Syntactic models**

- (a) transformational syntactic model
- (b) transformational generative syntactic model
 - sentence linguistic models
 - text linguistic models

(2) **Semantic models**

- (a) structural semantic models
- (b) transformational generative semantic model

(3) **Situational or denotative model**

(4) **The model of equivalence-levels**



The denotative (situational) model

Starting point = apart from some insignificant differences, there is a common reality surrounding us, and thus in linguistic interaction it is only the linguistic signs that differ, the signified objects, i.e. the denotata are the same.

■ in the **analysis** phase, the translator traces the SL signs back to the world of denotata common to all of us (this is where the name “denotative model” comes from), or, in other words, he/she clarifies which situation of the objective world is described by the SL text (this is where the name “situational model” originates from).

■ in the **synthesis** phase, he/she describes the same denotata, the same situations, using the devices of the TL



Advantages and disadvantages of the denotative model

A typical case of translation based on the denotative model is the translation of realia → the translator can make several choices:

- he/she can borrow the foreign word, equate it with a similar TL realia,
- invent a new TL word, etc.



Cont. Adv./disadv.

We translate according to the denotative model when there is only one possible solution in the TL for the naming or description of an object or situation English: *Keep off the grass*; Hungarian: *Fűre lépni tilos*. ('It is forbidden to step on the grass').

The denotative model cannot be used to explain cases when there are several alternatives for the description of a particular object/phenomenon in the TL and the translator has to choose the best one. In such cases the translator does not merely consider **what** the original text says, but also **how** it says it.



The transformational model

= views translation as simple substitution; the substitution of SL signs with TL signs.

■ This model, however, would only work, if the system of the SL and the TL were identical regarding the number, the distribution and operation of elements → obviously impossible

■ But this does not imply that there are no elements in any two Ls which would have the same distribution and would function following the same rules.

■ According to the transformational model, this common field serves as the basis for interlingual translation, which the translator reaches via a series of intralingual, i.e. language internal transformations.



The process of translation in the light of the transformational model

- (1) analysis phase: the translator goes back from the SL surface structure to the SL core sentences or deep structure via a series of transformations (**intralingual transformation**);
- (2) second phase: these are replaced by the equivalent core sentences or deep structure of the TL (**interlingual transformation**);
- (3) synthesis phase: the translator reaches the TL surface structure from the TL core sentences or deep structure via a series of transformations (**intralingual transformation**)



A similar description of the process of translation can be found in **Nida and Taber** (1969):

- analysis phase → they call “back-transformation”,
- synthesis phase → they call “restructuring”
- they assume a “transfer” phase in between.



Nida and Taber (1969):

- (1) analysis, in which the surface structure is analysed (“back-transformation”),
- (2) transfer, in which the analysed material is transferred in the mind of translator from language A to language B, and
- (3) “restructuring”, in which the transferred material is restructured in order to make the final message fully acceptable in the receptor language



Advantages of the transformational model

- In translator training → the idea that translation comprises a series of L internal transformations may be useful. Back-and-forth transformation of the surface sentences of the source text contributes to a better understanding of the text, and transformations carried out in producing the TL surface contribute to translators' awareness of the TL devices.
- In the assessment of translations → taking into consideration L internal transformations may also be helpful, in determining the degree of equivalence.
- In machine translation → If there exists a common area between the two Ls, i.e., if there are lexical units and grammatical structures in the two Ls whose equivalence can be predicted, then within this area there is no need for the skills or previous experience of a translator. This kind of transfer can be done even by a machine, with some pre- and post-editing.



Disadvantages:

- A defect of the transformational model is that, similarly to the denotative model, it creates a drastic separation between the SL text and the TL text. It does not take into account the important role of the SL form in creating the TL surface.
- It often happens in translation that certain SL and TL structures can be treated as equivalent despite the fact that they cannot be traced back to the common area between the two Ls. These may be classified as equivalences on the basis of the denotative-situational model; when the linguistic form plays almost no role in the translation: English: *Beware of the dog!*
Hungarian: *Vigyázz a kutya harap* ('Be careful, the dog bites').



The semantic model

- approach translation from the point of view of meaning or sense
- it became more and more fashionable to assume that the translator might be breaking down the words of the SL sentences into semantic constituents



The process of translation according to the semantic model:

- The transfer from one language to another happens through a **semantic deep structure** consisting of some system of basic meanings.



Melchuk and Zholkovskiy's (1965) semantic model

= sense $\rightarrow$ text $\rightarrow$ sense model

Process:

- (1) translator first understands the text to be translated
- (2) he/she expresses what he/she has understood in the given language, i.e. he/she expresses the **sense** of the text.



Semantic model cont.

The sense of the text refers to the common ground that can be found in all texts intuitively regarded identical with the given text. They intend to describe this common content-related invariant with the help of a special semantic language, the so called **basic language**.

→ Process of translation:

- the translator switches from idiomatic English to the English basic language (independent sense analysis),
- switches from the English basic language to the TL basic language (this is what can actually be considered translation),
- from the TL basic language he/she switches onto the idiomatic TL (independent sense synthesis).



Advantages of the semantic model

- In the process of translating, the translator does in fact go back to sense relations rather than to basic lexical units and grammatical structures.
- It is also self-evident that equivalences of basic lexical units and grammatical structures – be it intralingual or interlingual equivalence – can only be determined on the basis of identity of sense.



Komissarov's (1973) model: levels of equivalence

5 levels of transfer:

- (1) **the level of linguistic signs** (use of different words to produce utterances → several alternatives),
- (2) **the level of utterance** (linear ordering of Lic signs → several alternatives),
- (3) **the level of message** (the situation is described from various angles),
- (4) **the level of situation** (e.g., objects, persons, abstract phenomena in question),
- (5) **the level of communicative goal** (e.g., to inform).

→ several multi-level decisions

In **comprehending** the text, the receiver moves in the opposite direction: from the level of linguistic signs to the assumed communicative goal of the sender.



Translation process:

During **analysis**: he/she moves from the level of linguistic signs to the level of the communicative goal,

During **synthesis** he/she moves from the level of the communicative goal to the level of linguistic signs.



The advantages of the equivalence level model

- avoids the one-sidedness of the denotative and the transformational models, and successfully reflects the complexity of the work of the translator, who does not follow only one strategy
- In reality, elements with an equivalent on the level of linguistic signs are translated on the level of linguistic signs, and the step onto the “higher” levels as defined by Komissarov occurs only when no direct equivalences are found. (This, of course, will happen very soon, because even the simplest possessive or passive structure in an English sentence requires the translator to step to the next level in translating it into Hungarian.)



⇒ Translation: the joint functioning of two languages

- The translator constantly moves between the two Ls, constantly exploring the relationship of the SL and the TL signs to each other and to reality.
- The deeper the translator delves into the comprehension of the SL text, the more likely he/she is to reject TL options previously regarded appropriate.
- Therefore, the best way to characterise the process of translation is by looking at it as the joint functioning of two languages. → The linguistic models of the process of translation contribute to a better understanding of this complex process.

